

Introduction

Henry Cisneros, then-secretary of the U.S. Department of Housing and Urban Development, used his 1996 speech at a public housing summit to argue that American housing policymakers “[had] an obligation to...draw a line in the sand” between the “islands of misery” that characterized the subsidized housing of the past and modern policy in order to develop “public housing which works”, “lifts families up”, and “is a contribution, not a drain, on cities” (Drier, 1996). This new housing would go on to be characterized by social mixing, a housing policy that surged in popularity at the turn of the millennium as an interest in neighborhood effects research promised the Department of Housing and Urban Development (HUD) an alternative approach to subsidized housing that tended to concentrate low-income households (and, accordingly, the negative lifetime outcomes associated with poverty) within single neighborhoods. Policymakers hoped to use housing policies of social mixing not only to reduce negative lifetime outcomes associated with poverty, but potentially lift households out of poverty by improving their socioeconomic outcomes through the mechanisms of neighborhood effects. Within the American context, the Moving to Opportunity (MTO) experiment—a policy that offered housing vouchers for poor families to move into higher-income neighborhoods—is the most prominent example of social mixing policies from the turn of the millennium and offers an excellent case study for analysis of U.S. social mixing policy. In my analysis, I describe MTO’s origins and methods and evaluate its impacts, ultimately placing its design and effects in the context of the larger landscape of social mixing policies within the U.S. and internationally. While MTO was not successful as a tool for poverty reduction, it was a helpful experiment, providing the international scholarly community with valuable data on social mixing and ultimately echoing the modern consensus that though social mixing policies can improve some quality of life measures, they are largely ineffective as tools for improving socioeconomic outcomes of recipient households and individuals. This has important implications for U.S. housing policy as HUD even now continues to move forward with social mixing-based policies, providing reasons to change existing directions of research on socioeconomic improvement policies and reframe social mixing strategies as quality of life interventions.

Neighborhood Effects: Rationales of Social Mixing Policies

Before discussing the literature surrounding social mixing and policymaker rationales for enacting social mixing policies, it is important to specify what I mean by the term, as well as additional considerations about what secondary effects and demographic changes tend to come with social mix. Musterd and Andersson (2005, p. 762) provide a basic definition of a social mix as “a mix of households according to their socioeconomic position”. Social mixing policies, like the Moving to Opportunity program that will be the focus of my analysis, typically adhere to this definition and focus on encouraging a socioeconomic mix in a targeted area. However, it is important to understand that the socioeconomic position of an individual does not stand alone in determining their status as a social mixing policy recipient: it is highly correlated with other characteristics like race, ethnicity, or immigration status (LaVeist, 2005; Siddiq and Najand, 2022; Williams, 1996). For example, due to a long history of discrimination in housing toward Black and other minority groups that I will touch on later in my analysis, social mixing policies in the United States are tightly entangled with national efforts toward racial desegregation (Musterd, 2022). Therefore, it must be kept in mind that social mixing policies around the world are frequently connected to considerations about demographic variables other than socioeconomic status.

Social mixing policies are based in the idea of neighborhood effects—that the place in which someone lives exerts influence over their social, health, and economic outcomes in ways that cannot be accounted for by household- and individual-level factors, with a historical focus in the literature on the negative impacts of residence in poor neighborhoods and potential resolution of such impacts through “deconcentration of poverty”. The idea that residence in certain neighborhoods accounts for individual and household outcomes has a long history in sociological and economic scholarship, with notable

research on the topic including Polyani (1944) and Granovetter's (1985) discussion of the embeddedness of economic activity in social relations and institutions, or Shaw and McKay's (1942) introduction of social disorganization theory linking crime in certain areas to neighborhood collective action. However, its application to the American urban studies space took hold with the publishing of Wilson's (1987) *The Truly Disadvantaged*, which argued that the social isolation of poor Black and other nonwhite households as a result of their disproportionate concentration in the U.S. inner city worsened their socioeconomic outcomes and advocated for the introduction of policies focusing on reducing the social isolation of the poor generally. In the following decades, planning-oriented research surrounding neighborhood effects took off, producing a wave of studies on the topic; overwhelming interest remained in the role of a neighborhood's concentration of poverty on resident outcomes (Leventhal and Brooks-Gunn, 2000; Massey, 1996; Mayer and Jencks, 1989; Morenoff and Sampson, 1997; Sampson and Raudenbusch, 1999).

Policymakers at the time, moving alongside the explosion of literature, took a keen interest in the potential of intervention in neighborhood effects through housing policy that created social mixing (with particular attention paid to the impacts that could be made on resident outcomes by altering the wealth composition of neighborhoods) (Vale and Freemark, 2012). A number of mechanisms by which these social mixing policies would "raise all boats" were proposed, including: social contagion, in which more advantaged neighbors would act as role models in terms of behavior and life choices; social control, in which advantaged households would enforce social order and thereby reduce the negative impacts of phenomena like crime; institutional mechanisms of wealthier neighborhoods fostering higher-quality institutions, such as higher-paid and thus better teachers in schools; the social connection of disadvantaged residents to wealthier, more well-connected neighbors who could act as sources of networking opportunities; and the reduction of social stigma attached to a uniformly poor neighborhood through the introduction of wealthy households or the movement of poor families to wealthier areas providing increased opportunities for employment due to increased business willingness to operate in a less impoverished area (Kintrea, 2013; Galster, 2012). Through these mechanisms, social mixing policy advocates reasoned, the outcomes of poor individuals and households who either moved to a wealthier neighborhood or had wealthy households move to *their* neighborhood could be improved. However, questions about research into these mechanisms persisted. Jencks and Mayer (1990) note that studies at the time remained mostly descriptive, treating the neighborhood as a "black box" through which unspecified mechanisms acted on residents.

Results of neighborhood effects studies were mixed: while studies found an overwhelming *correlation* between neighborhood characteristics and resident outcomes, there remained little consensus on the existence of a *causal* relationship between the two (Leventhal and Brooks-Gunn, 2000; Massey, 1996; Mayer and Jencks, 1989; Morenoff and Sampson, 1997; Sampson and Raudenbusch, 1999). A number of questions remained about how results were to be explained. Sampson et al. (2002, p. 443), in their overview of studies produced during this wave, point out "a set of thorny methodological problems that plague[d] neighborhood effects research" that call into question whether or not existing studies had successfully decoupled neighborhood-level factors from individual- and household-level ones, with selection bias—the question of "how...we know that the area differences in any outcome of interest, such as adolescent delinquency, are the result of neighborhood factors rather than the differential selection of adolescents or their families into certain neighborhoods" (p. 466)—a primary concern. Sharkey and Faber (2014) note that existing understanding of the mechanisms behind proposed neighborhood effects remains murky, marking a shift in neighborhood effects scholarship toward more nuanced understandings of the association between where people live and their life outcomes that focus on specific *aspects* of neighborhoods (for example, schools or available social services) instead of the neighborhood as a whole. Using new evidence from social mixing policies that resulted from policy interest in neighborhood effects and poverty concentration, modern-day consensus on neighborhood effects has echoed this sentiment, pointing to the lack of robust evidence for the role of the neighborhood generally in universally transforming resident outcomes apart from quality of life changes and potential differential outcomes for children (Manley et al., 2011; Tunstall and Lupton, 2010; Chyn and Katz, 2021).

Grappling with Spatial Segregation in the United States

The current landscape of housing in the United States is an intensely segregated one, shaped by development that historically prioritized the demographic of white homeowners at the expense of Black and other minority households and neighborhoods. The New Deal-era Home Owner's Loan Corporation (HOLC), explicitly and systematically denied mortgages to households in predominantly Black neighborhoods, preventing would-be Black homebuyers from assembling generational wealth through redlining practices (Rothstein, 2017). Trends of discriminatory lending continued with the implementation of the post-WWII G.I. Bill, which overwhelmingly denied loans to Black veterans and their families in favor of white mortgage-takers, who in large numbers took advantage of cheap, accessible mortgages to buy homes in burgeoning suburbs outside of cities enabled by the development of the interstate highway system (Katznelson, 2023; Mohl, 2002; van Weesep and Priemus, 1999). The exit of white residents from private and subsidized housing in cities—a phenomenon referred to in modern scholarship as white flight—left urban areas to be occupied predominantly by Black and other minorities. Households unable to afford homes on a private market, already increasingly boxed in by projects of urban renewal that overwhelmingly targeted historically Black neighborhoods for demolition, turned to subsidized units. These units, due to concerns about cost and neighborhood opposition, were built in areas that were already overwhelmingly poor (Heathcott, 2015; Hunt 2018; Schwartz, 2021). Urban subsidized housing, experiencing a demographic transition as it came to house “the poorest of the poor”, became intensely stigmatized by stories of violence and poor outcomes in “infamous” subsidized housing projects like the Robert Taylor Homes in New York City or Pruitt-Iggo in St. Louis. Housing the nation's poorest had also taken a financial toll on HUD and its constituent agencies, which began to struggle with maintenance—something that only contributed further to negative reputations of subsidized housing (Bloom et al., 2015). Buildings of subsidized-only units had become a liability. The assembly of the National Commission on Severely Distressed Public Housing marked a growing federal concern regarding the state of urban subsidized housing—one that coincided with a corresponding growth of interest in neighborhood effects, which offered the alternative of socially-mixed housing as a low-cost housing solution that could also not only improve residents' socioeconomic outcomes, but potentially help bring them out of poverty completely. When the Commission's final 1992 report came out, political will surrounding subsidized housing had already shifted away from supporting existing programs toward social mixing ones (Goetz, 2012; Vale and Freemark, 2012).

The rise of scholarly interest in neighborhood effects and social embeddedness, combined with federal policy toward subsidized housing that had begun to prioritize cost effectiveness and shifted from affordable units as “battlefield hospitals” (Vale and Freemark, 2012, p. 386) for the symptoms of poverty to treatments for the affliction of poverty itself, encouraged the federal government to turn to social mixing policies as a social welfare solution fit for the twenty-first century: one that wouldn't just resolve housing insecurity at a lower cost than before, but ensure happier, healthier, and wealthier lives for recipient households. Existing private developer- and landlord-led subsidized housing initiatives that had been introduced in the 1970s and 80s—namely, the 1974 Section 8 Existing Housing program (which gave recipients vouchers that could be used in the private market) and the 1986 Low Income Housing Tax Credit (which provided tax credits to firms who developed or invested in the construction of low- or mixed-income housing)—could be retrofitted to this new focus, making it a fairly simple shift of direction rather than creation of an entirely new set of programs (Marcuse, 1995; Schwartz, 2021). Mixed-income developments became the hallmark of new policies such as HOPE VI that were intended to succeed existing subsidized housing models. Policymakers argued that such developments, through the mechanisms of neighborhood effects, would not only improve general quality of life, but actively reduce poverty by improving resident socioeconomic outcomes (HUD and CNU, 2000; HUD and CNU, n.d.). The Moving to Opportunity (MTO) program, introduced in 1994, offered a chance for these arguments to be put to the test.

Moving to Opportunity

The Moving to Opportunity for Fair Housing Demonstration Program was, first and foremost, an experiment on the basics of social mixing: per its 1999 Current Status and Initial Findings Report, the program sought to “measure definitively and understand the impacts of a change in neighborhood on the employment, income, educational achievements, and social well-being of low-income, public housing families...[and] test the hypothesis that escaping from troubled neighborhoods helps poor people escape poverty” (HUD, p.3). A number of mechanisms by which this proposed “escape from poverty” would occur, following strands of thought in existing research, were suggested (see HUD, 2011, p. 4, Figure 1).

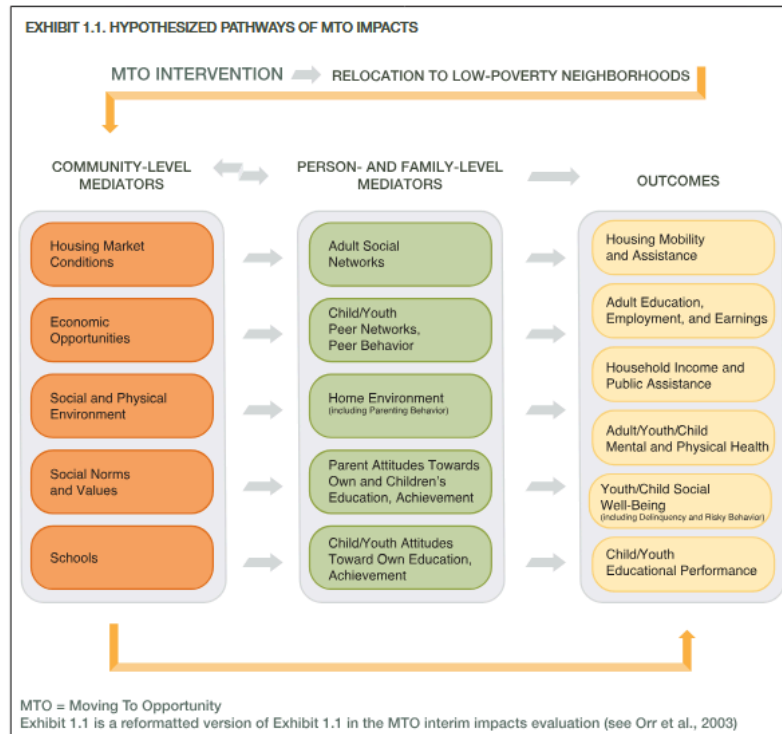


Figure 1. Hypothesized pathways of MTO impacts. (HUD, 2011) Source: *Moving to Opportunity for Fair Housing Demonstration Program: Final Impacts Evaluation*.

MTO was also among the first of its kind as a randomized controlled trial, born out of the need to examine the impacts of a social mixing policy that did not allow households to self-select into the program. As the 1999 Initial Findings report goes on to note:

MTO was designed as a major social science improvement over earlier research that failed to address the problem of self-selection bias: that if only the most motivated families are included or selected to join a program, their experiences—including measured results or outcomes—will not be typical of the eligible population and will confound or confuse outcomes (Jencks and Mayer, 1990)...Highly motivated families might have succeeded in moving and improving their lives even without the assistance of a special demonstration program. (HUD, 1999, p.3)

Families living in public housing in high-poverty areas of five major cities across the U.S.—Boston, Baltimore, Chicago, Los Angeles, and New York City—were given the chance to volunteer for MTO. However, volunteering for the program did not mean that the family would be part of a treatment group.

Of the 4,610 families selected for the program, most were Black or Hispanic households headed by single mothers, with a small number of households that were two-parent and/or white (Leventhal and Brooks-Gunn, 2003). Participating families were randomly assigned membership in one of three groups: a control group that did not receive any interventions, a group that received housing vouchers and support typically allotted under Section 8, and a treatment group that received special support in finding a unit and Section 8 vouchers only allowed to be used in low-poverty areas (specifically, areas in which the 1989 poverty rate was under ten percent). Of regular Section 8 and MTO Section 8 groups, the majority of the 4,610 original families were able to successfully sign new leases, meaning the final experiment would study 3,116 households in total. Results would be gathered in the form of two evaluations: an interim evaluation four to seven years after the program's start, and then a final evaluation after ten to fifteen years of the program. These evaluations would come in the form of surveys asking participating households about their social and family lives, employment, education, living conditions, health, and criminal behavior, among a number of other aspects of their lives (HUD, 2003; HUD, 2011).

As an experiment, the MTO was incredibly illuminating, offering a body of evidence that continues to be referenced today with regard to social mixing policies in the U.S. and abroad (Galster, 2012; Manley et al., 2011; Tunstall and Lupton, 2010). However, its achievements and shortcomings as a policy to reduce poverty and improve other household outcomes are far more mixed, continuing to be a source of intense debate among researchers to this day. HUD assessment of the program's impact at its interim described "disappointing" (HUD, 2011, p. xv) outcomes: while MTO treatment group households reported improved health and perceived safety outcomes as a result of having moved to more well-off neighborhoods, with a number of participants noting a reduction in concerns about crime in their new neighborhoods, no significant changes in employment or educational outcomes of participants assigned to the MTO group were exhibited (HUD, 2003; Kling et al., 2004). Final HUD evaluation results were also mixed. Both MTO and regular Section 8 households were found to have slightly improved social mobility outcomes, reporting social connections with wealthier households and slightly reduced rates of neighborhood segregation compared to the control, as well as improved perceptions of neighborhood safety and housing quality. Adults in MTO and Section 8 households also experienced some mild health improvements related to weight, diabetes, and perceived health quality. Most outcomes related to criminal activity were overall not affected by either MTO or regular Section 8 treatment, though differential behavioral and mental health outcomes were noted among children based on gender: boys tended to be negatively impacted by treatment, while girls experienced slight improvements. Most notably for the ultimate goal of the study as having an interest in the impacts of social mixing on socioeconomic outcomes, employment and education outcomes did not appear to be affected by either treatment as compared to the control group (HUD, 2011). Outside studies drew overwhelmingly similar conclusions, also noting slight improvements in health and perceived well-being outcomes related to environmental quality (in terms of housing quality, neighborhood safety, etc.), but generally finding few to no statistically significant impacts of either MTO or regular Section 8 treatment on adult employment or children's educational outcomes (Briggs et al., 2010; Chyn and Katz, 2021; Kintrea, 2013; Leventhal and Brooks-Gunn, 2013; Ludwig et al., 2013; Ludwig et al., 2008; Manley et al., 2011; Silver, 2013; Tunstall and Lupton, 2010). MTO, in being a successful study on the impacts of social mixing, fell short as a policy specifically to reduce poverty precisely by providing little evidence to show that social mixing would do such a thing.

MTO in Context

When looking at the implementation and results of social mixing policies across the globe in the past few decades, scholarship is generally clear that the evidence for social mixing as a tool to improve long-term socioeconomic prospects—i.e., "life chances"—of individuals and households is dubious even on an international scale. Some scholarship indicates that it is occasionally helpful to separate discussion of the larger U.S. context from that of the international context when discussing specifics: for example, meta-analyses of social mixing literature note that U.S. studies tend to find stronger evidence for

neighborhood effects than those in Europe (Galster, 2012; van Kempen and Bolt, 2012). However, international discussion of the social mixing literature is clear that social mixing is not a silver bullet for poverty reduction and assumptions behind proposed mechanisms of neighborhood effects (generally, that neighbors actually interact with each other and share the same institutions due to geographic proximity) are flawed (Bolt and van Kempen, 2013; Manley et al., 2011; Tunstall and Lupton, 2010): as Silver (2013, p. 73) points out, “everyone seems to agree that the built environment of mixed-income developments is an improvement from public housing, but that poverty and social relations have not improved”.

The example of MTO, then, does not stand out among other social mixing policies and studies for its results; however, it is fairly unique, even on an international scale, for the direction and type of its mixing. The overwhelming majority of policies intending to reduce concentrations of poverty or levels of segregation in an area have attempted to do so by introducing advantaged groups to a disadvantaged area, typically through the construction of mixed-income developments in place of previously uniform social housing units. Such policies have been introduced, among other places, in the United States in the form of the HOPE VI and Choice Neighborhoods initiatives (Bulger et al., 2023; Joseph, 2006); in the United Kingdom in the form of large-scale regeneration of council estates (Watt, 2021); and in the Netherlands through mixed districts as part of the Big Cities and Urban Restructuring Policies (van Kempen and Bolt, 2009). These programs, centered around the introduction of wealthy (and typically white) residents into poor neighborhoods as new residents of mixed-income developments, have faced a number of accusations of acting as state-led gentrification projects (Crump, 2002; Hochstenbach, 2017; Reades et al., 2023). Moving to Opportunity, as a program that moved poor households into wealthier neighborhoods, provides a striking contrast in this respect, instead finding similarity in the earlier U.S. Gautreaux Assisted Housing program. Cited in MTO documents as an example of a social mixing policy that suffered from selection bias (HUD, 1999), Gautreaux also distinguished itself from MTO through its focus on social mixing on the basis of race instead of class: while the MTO saw mostly Black and Hispanic treatment groups move into neighborhoods with only slightly higher proportions of white residents, Gautreaux assisted the movement of low-income Black families into neighborhoods that were majority white (Chyn et al., 2023). Moving to Opportunity, by providing a comprehensive set of data on the impacts of moving poor households into more economically well-off neighborhoods, generally sets itself apart from other policies seeking to improve the economic mix of neighborhoods. However, its connection to a program like Gautreaux also highlights the intimate connections between social mixing as an economic strategy and one that, as a result of the tight entanglement of ethnic background and class (especially in the United States), also frequently seeks to address the impacts of racial segregation.

In light of the contemporary understanding of social mixing policies’ effectiveness, it is also worth looking into its place in modern HUD policy. Despite the results of MTO and similar findings not just in the U.S., but internationally, social mixing policies are still espoused by HUD as a way to improve socioeconomic prospects of recipients. The modern-day successor of the poverty reduction ethos of MTO, the Choice Neighborhoods Program, has invested 1.8 billion dollars as of 2024 in grants into mixed-income developments with one of its primary goals being the “[improvement of] outcomes for residents, related to employment and income, health, and children’s education” (HUD, 2024, p. iii). Despite the lessons learned by MTO and other studies, Choice Neighborhoods marks an overall persistence by HUD in attempting to use social mixing as a way to improve socioeconomic outcomes.

Conclusion

Moving to Opportunity originated from a shift by HUD around the turn of the millennium toward social mixing policies as a way to improve subsidized housing recipients’ socioeconomic outcomes through the proposed mechanisms of neighborhood effects, which as an idea had taken off due to rising interest in the negative impacts of concentrations of urban poverty and the potential for more socioeconomically diverse neighborhoods to improve poor residents’ outcomes. In my analysis of the program, I found that MTO itself, which was a randomized controlled trial that offered vouchers for low-poverty neighborhoods to subsidized housing residents living in high-poverty areas, was ultimately

unsuccessful as a social mixing policy that sought to improve socioeconomic outcomes. However, as a study, it contributed valuable data to scholarship on social mixing that has come to help scholars establish an international consensus that the potential of social mixing programs to reduce poverty is limited (though they may still be helpful in improving resident quality of life). The legacy of MTO and social mixing research as a whole is especially important in the context of social mixing's continued promotion as a way to positively impact employment, education, and other similar life trajectory measures in recent HUD programs like Choice Neighborhoods: though social mixing policies can be valuable in improving resident outcomes related to health and happiness in daily life, there is ample evidence to support investigating the potential of policies other than social mixing in improving socioeconomic outcomes.

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